

Tips for designing a survey

1. Keep it Simple

Avoid technical language, acronyms, or complex options that might confuse respondents and define any terms or phrases that could be left to interpretation

2. Be Consistent

Use the same or similar scales throughout the survey (ex. if using a scale from 1-5 be consistent about whether 5 is high or low)

3. Make it Relevant

Focus on gathering information that is directly related to the purpose of your survey; avoid questions that lack a clear relationship to the topic

4. Brief is Best

Limit the survey to essential questions to respect respondents' time. Aim for a survey that can be completed within 5-7 minutes to maximize response rates and data quality

5. Collect Anonymous Responses

Assure respondents that their answers are confidential and anonymous and reject responses that contain identifying information; this will encourage honesty and ensure compliance with data privacy regulations

6. Provide Clear Instructions

Provide explicit instructions on how to complete and return the survey to ensure that the process is straightforward and that there are no barriers to responses or submission

7. Think Ahead About Your Data

Consider which data points you will need in order to effectively analyze the results of your survey and design responses in a way that will allow responses to be easily aggregated and understood

8. Capture Demographic Details

Include demographic questions to identify and analyze trends across different market segments; try to capture insights about income level, employment status, age, geography, etc.

9. Consider Trade-Off Analysis

Incorporate questions that require respondents to make choices between two or more competing preferences

10. Ask Follow-Up Questions

To deepen the understanding of certain preferences, include follow-up questions that explore why respondents made specific choices

11. Avoid Influence of Bias

Use objective language to ensure you are capturing authentic responses; questions should not be 'leading' respondents toward a specific answer

12. Be MECE (Mutually Exclusive, Collectively Exhaustive)

Ask enough questions to ensure you are gathering all of the data you need while making sure you do not ask the same question multiple times